Buffering & Swarming

Protect capacity for the unexpected, and agree when the team stops starting and gathers to finish.

Manage Flow · Capacity Buffer · Swarm Triggers · Stop Starting, Start Finishing

TEAM _____

DATE _____

1 Unplanned Work History

HOW MUCH SURPRISE WORK DO WE REALLY GET?

ITERATION	PLANNED CAPACITY	UNPLANNED WORK	% UNPLANNED	NOTES

Average % unplanned over the last 5: _____

2 Size the Buffer

Buffer this iteration (%): _____

In days or items: _____

The buffer is for:

- [ ] Support, incidents & bugs
- [ ] Urgent requests
- [ ] Swarming & helping others
- [ ] Improvement work, if unused

3 Buffer Rules

What counts as unplanned?

Who decides to use it?

If it runs out, we…

If it's unused, we…

4 Swarm Triggers

WHEN WE STOP STARTING AND SWARM

- [ ] An item is blocked for more than _____ hours
- [ ] An item is older than _____ days (our 85% SLE)
- [ ] An item the goal depends on is at risk with _____ days left
- [ ] A production incident at severity _____ or higher
- [ ] A column is at its WIP limit _____

Our own trigger: _____

5 How We Swarm

AGREE IT BEFORE YOU NEED IT

1 Stop
Don't start anything new. Say "swarm" at the board.
Our note: _____

2 Gather
Whoever can help joins. Not everyone needs to, just enough.
Our note: _____

3 Plan
What's the next step to finish it? Who does which part?
Our note: _____

4 Work it
Pair or mob. Test while building. Clear the blocker.
Our note: _____

5 Reflect
Done? Log it below. Why did it need a swarm at all?
Our note: _____

6 Swarm Log

LEARN FROM EVERY SWARM

DATE	ITEM	TRIGGER	WHO SWARMED	TIME TO DONE	WHAT WE LEARNED

7 Iteration Check

AT THE RETRO

Buffer used last iteration (%): _____

Number of swarms: _____

Did swarming finish things faster?

- [ ] Yes
- [ ] Partly
- [ ] No

Next iteration's buffer (%): _____

"What would we stop starting so we could finish this?"

"How much of our plan is really for surprises?"

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